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VIPIN KUMAR, *Chairman, Airports Authority of India*

tered. The CAG later found that most heliports were under-equipped and unsafe, with feasibility studies either rushed or missing. Helicopter operations in Uttarakhand remain hazardous. In 2025 alone, two major crashes occurred on the Char Dham routes, claiming 13 lives, blamed on steep terrain and sudden weather changes.

Unpredictable weather, combined with the lack of an instrument landing system (ILS), is also a key reason why Pakyong Airport in Sikkim has remained closed since June 2024. "Small Udan airports lack ILS, necessitating high visibility to operate. This causes frequent cancellations across the north, east and northeast routes," explains V.P. Agarwal, former chairman of AAI.

SO, WHO'S PAYING?

The problem is that the real cost of these grounded airports is borne not by the operators, but by the public exchequer. Across the 20 'non-operational' airports, routine expenses on maintenance, electricity and staffing add up to over Rs 90 crore annually. The CAG estimated that Rs 1,089 crore were spent on developing Udan airports and heliports that never opened or closed prematurely. This, when the AAI's operational losses have touched Rs 10,853 crore over the past decade.

Still, AAI chairman Vipin Kumar remains upbeat. "Once an airport is ready, flights will have to operate there, even if they are not operational now," he says. "With the growth in aviation, these airports will be vital in expanding India's domestic network." Kaul agrees—up to a point. "Eventually, these airports will connect, and some of the airlines will be viable," he says. "But till then, it continues to be a hard choice."

The civil aviation ministry insists that Udan is functioning as intended. "It is a demand-driven [scheme]," minister of state for civil aviation Murlidhar Mohol told Parliament in March. "Airlines run routes that are commercially viable. The government [provides] infrastructure and incentives, but it does not control how a business should function." Officials also point out that 46 of the 114 discontinued routes were later revived—26 with VGF concessions and 20 without—suggesting that the model can mature over time.

The government is now pushing Udan 5.5, which aims to link 120 more destinations—including helipads and water aerodromes—over the next decade. But analysts warn that expansion without reform risks repeating old mistakes. "Unless regional airports attract substantial traffic volumes, generating revenue from both aeronautical and non-aeronautical sources will remain a challenge," says a CAPA advisory. Even the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Transport, Tourism and Culture has called for a specialised asset utilisation optimisation model to identify inefficiencies at underperforming airports and explore alternative aviation uses for such facilities.

FILLING THE GAPS

- Airports/ routes were launched without solid feasibility studies, leading to weak traffic, incomplete infrastructure and heavy reliance on subsidies
- A data-driven Route Viability Matrix can prioritise airports where passenger potential, road/rail alternatives and local economic activity justify air links
- Proposed routes should be evaluated holistically; airlines asked for a business plan before bidding

A SECOND WIND

Policymakers are constantly on the lookout to use or repurpose idle assets. While Udan is driving the restoration of smaller regional terminals, bigger assets are being leased out to private entities under the National Monetisation Pipeline. The civil enclave at Hindon near Delhi has been operationalised for regional connectivity, with scheduled commercial flights now connecting it to cities like Nanded and Adampur. Similarly, Salem Airport in Tamil Nadu has emerged as a destination for Flying Training Organisations (FTOs) and has successfully resumed operations to Chennai. "If you can't keep them alive commercially, at least make the assets work," says a senior government official.

Nor is it entirely a lost cause, as some routes have taken off. Like Darbhanga in Bihar, which has seen record-breaking traffic around Diwali and Chhath—76,000 passengers and 522 flights in just one month. Routes like Jalgaon–Mumbai and Jharsuguda–Kolkata have turned profitable for operators even after subsidies lapsed. "The fact remains that Udan has made flying accessible to the common man," says Vipin Kumar. "Today, everyone can consider air travel alongside trains and buses. That will continue." However, the true test will lie in whether these airports will someday support flights that fly on demand, not subsidies. ■